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County to promote its heritage on Saturday

By: J.D. Prose
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Historical sites and museums across Beaver County will work in tandem Saturday to promote the county's heritage as part of the third annual Beaver County History Day.

Between 10 a.m. and 4 p.m., 17 attractions will offer either tour guides or re-enactors to help visitors experience the county's past.

"All of them offer something different," said Brenda Applegate, executive director of the Beaver County Historical Research and Landmarks Foundation.

Venues included in Saturday's showcase range from well-known spots such as Vicary Mansion in Freedom, Old Economy Village in Ambridge and the Merrick Art Gallery in New Brighton, to lesser-known sites such as the Greek Catholic Union's St. Nicholas Chapel in Brighton Township and the McKinley School in Chippewa Township.

Applegate said the event has "definitely grown" since its first year, with some sites seeing double the number of visitors. She also said the diversity of the attractions offers something for everyone.

As an example, Applegate recalled her first visit to the Air Heritage Museum at the Beaver County Airport when she thought she was going to be bored. She said she was pleasantly surprised and could have spent several hours there.

"It was so neat to see what this group of volunteers has been doing with these airplanes," she said.

Applegate singled out the Monaca Community Hall of Fame as an example for other towns.

"They're showing what each of our communities should be doing to recognize people from our communities," she said.

Funding for historical sites is dwindling, Applegate said, and events such as History Day serve to remind people of their importance and vulnerability.

"We need to make our public aware that if another generation doesn't come in and help us preserve these sites, we're going to lose them," she said.

BRIDGEWATER'S BIRTHDAY

Bridgewater will celebrate its 175th anniversary at 3 p.m. Saturday with a community picnic by the pavillion on Riverside Drive. Each household will receive a commemorative key chain, and the opening celebration will include the release of 175 balloons. The oldest resident, business, church and house will also be recognized.

MAGICAL HISTORY TOUR

On Saturday between 10 a.m. and 4 p.m., 17 historical sites and museums will take part in the third annual Beaver County History Day. For a complete list of participating sites, visit www.bchrlf.org and click on the scrolling link for History Day. Donations are accepted at the sites. For more information, call (724) 775-1848.